

brand operating system — setup & adoption guide

five steps from an empty scaffold to a brand operating system you can actually operate.

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what this is

this guide takes you from an empty brand operating system scaffold to a populated, governed system your team can operate against.

the kit is 12 governance-first folders, 39 first-level subfolders, ordered by the **chain of command**. evidence at the top, execution at the bottom, scaling and archive at the end.

plan ~30 minutes for a first pass. populating the folders with real content is ongoing — measured in weeks, not minutes.

doing this as brandhorse onboarding? open [00_START_HERE.md](#) at the scaffold root — it's the guided path (audit → research pass → charter pass → ratify) and wires in the two prompts that do the heavy lifting.

what this is not

- **a brand strategy.** the scaffold holds your strategy — it doesn't replace it.
 - **an asset library.** assets live in [09_execution/assets/](#), downstream of the decisions that make them defensible.
 - **a one-time deliverable.** the system is a living artifact. the value compounds with use.
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the one rule: evidence first, charter derived

[00_charter/](#) is numbered first because it's the constitutional layer every downstream folder inherits from — **that's its authority, not the order you build it in.**

you build the charter *from evidence*. author it cold, before the research, and you'll produce a brand nobody can defend the moment it's challenged. that mistake is the single most common reason a brand falls apart under pressure — and it's the exact trap this kit exists to prevent.

so:

authority (what inherits from what): 00 → 01 → 02 → 03 → 04 → 05 → 06 → 07 → 08 → 09 → 10
build order (what you populate first): 01 → 02 → 03, then 00 (derived), then 04 → 05 → 06 → 07 →

00 is where everything inherits from. 01 is where you start.

the chain of command

every brand decision is downstream of an upstream one. the folder numbers reflect the dependency direction — and, for everything except the charter, the order you populate them.

folder	holds
00_charter	the non-negotiables: truth set, decision rights, charter — derived from evidence, not authored cold
01_evidence	► start here. raw signals — quotes, observations, market data, internal proof
02_patterns-and-insights	what the evidence reveals
03_personas-and-profiles	who you serve, who you don't, who you used to
04_positioning-and-messaging	governed positioning, message map, claims library
05_voice-and-anti-voice	how the brand speaks — and the things it can never say
06_rules-and-guardrails	the rule library compliance runs against
07_approved-canon	frameworks the brand has committed to
08_briefs-and-templates	briefs anchor every campaign
09_execution	shipped work — assets, campaigns, channel-shipped, compliance runs
10_scaling-and-learning	experiments, performance, decisions log, recaps
99_archive	deprecated — kept, not deleted

*the rule: if a downstream folder feels confusing, the answer is almost always upstream.
don't add structure to the wrong layer to compensate.*

five-step adoption

the same order is in `USAGE.md` at the repo root. build **upward from evidence** — the charter is derived, not written first.

1. fork or clone. use "use this template" on github (clean history) or fork. no git? download the zip from brandhorse.com/resources/brand-operating-system-starter-kit and unzip wherever it should live. (*where will this live? who has read access? who has write?*)

2. populate evidence — this is where you start. open `01_evidence/`. drop in customer quotes (interviews, calls, tickets, reviews), competitive observations, market signals, and whatever internal proof you have. benchmark: ~30 rows before you synthesize. the research-pass prompt runs this collection for you. (*pre-revenue? expect little internal proof on pass one — that's correct, not a gap.*)

3. synthesize up to patterns and personas. once evidence is real, work upward: `02_patterns-and-insights/` (what recurs, what it means), then `03_personas-and-profiles/` (who it's for, who it isn't). don't skip ahead — positioning language with nothing in `02` is guessing.

4. derive and ratify your charter. now open `00_charter/`. with evidence and synthesis behind you, the charter is a derivation. the charter-drafting pass turns your evidence into draft clauses (mission, values, non-negotiables, excluded audiences, decision rights) plus open questions and thin-evidence flags. answer the open questions and ratify — lock it. everything below inherits from it.

5. articulate downstream, then document ownership. work down the chain — `04` positioning → `05` voice → `06` rules → `07` canon — each inheriting from the ratified charter and citing evidence. then add an `OWNERSHIP.md` at root (folder · owner · backup); owners review quarterly. without ownership, the system rots.

common mistakes

- **writing the charter first, cold.** `00` is first for authority, not build order. derive it from evidence, or it's opinion in a constitution's clothes.
- **putting logos at the top.** they're in `09_execution/assets/`. logos can't be defended without positioning; positioning can't be defended without evidence.

- **articulation before evidence.** positioning/messaging/voice written before [01_evidence/](#) produces a brand nobody can defend. it shows up later as "rebrand fatigue."
 - **voice without anti-voice.** "confident, friendly, clear" is meaningless because nothing is excluded.
 - **treating canon as preference.** canon is what's been *approved*. if it can change without a charter-level decision, it isn't canon yet.
 - **letting [99_archive/](#) become a graveyard.** the archive teaches — what we tried, why we stopped. an undocumented archive is worse than a deleted file.
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what good looks like at 30 · 60 · 90 days

- **30 days** — [01_evidence/](#) has 30+ rows across the four sub-folders. primary ICP defined in [03](#) with provenance. charter drafted from that evidence and posted in [00_charter/](#).
 - **60 days** — patterns and insights synthesized in [02](#). positioning and message map in [04](#). voice and anti-voice in [05](#). ownership documented at root.
 - **90 days** — rule library active in [06](#). approved canon in [07](#). first brief in [08](#) generated against the populated chain. first campaign shipped in [09](#) from a brief that inherited governance. first compliance run logged.
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when you need more than structure

this scaffold is the file system. when you want the methodology behind it or the running os, brandhorse maintains a ladder:

- **brand self-audit — free.** 10-minute diagnostic scoring your brand across all five r.a.c.e.s.™ phases; tells you which folders to populate first. → brandhorse.com/brand-audit
- **brand mastery essentials — free.** the eBook that grounds the mindset behind the whole system. → brandhorse.com/brand-mastery-essentials
- **r.a.c.e.s.™ methodology workbook — \$79.** the complete methodology + notion companion. the thinking behind every folder here. → brandhorse.com/products/races-methodology-workbook
- **brand mastery blueprint — from \$39 (eBook) · \$89 complete bundle.** the operator's reference for running the chain, in multiple formats. → brandhorse.com/products/brand-mastery-blueprint-bundle
- **brandhorse os — membership.** the governed operating system. run r.a.c.e.s.™ end-to-end with traceable evidence and approved canon. the scaffold instrumented as a live system. → brandhorse.com/request-access

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